messages were exchanged with my fellow team members for weeks on end. Each of us proposed our own vision on what we could do. But we came together for the larger cause and amicably amalgamated our different ideas. But soon the famous saying ‘Man proposes, God disposes’ kicked in. At the back of my mind, I had always suspected that no amount of preparedness could ever suffice. We can put together the most impeccable roadmap, yet never quite prognosticate the road ahead. And that’s what ended up happening! But I can’t complain. In fact, the reality of what we experienced and grappled with only amplified the adventure we had set out on.

On the very first day of Onam, the Bharat Jodo Yatra knocked on the doors of a festive Thiruvananthapuram in God’s own country. Being my first All India Congress Committee (AICC) assignment, most of those present were strangers to me, except for my two teammates, Lavanya Ballal and Neeraj Mishra. Having ensured the facilitation of necessary staples for the media fraternity riding the signature ‘Media Truck’, which ran a few metres ahead of the man of the show, I marched along with the Sewa Dal group nearly 2 kilometres ahead of the main cavalcade, arriving at the press conference venue. It was already packed with the media, so it was quite unnerving to find that there was no internet connectivity, which was a serious problem, given that our primary agenda was to launch the Bharat Jodo Yatra anthem! Nonetheless, with a lot of team spirit and a healthy dose of the famous Indian jugaad (make-do solution), Lavanya distracted the house, I paired my phone to the LED screen and Neeraj stood behind the wall right outside the room to ensure his mobile hotspot gave us internet inside. Before anything else went awry, the anthem was launched without incident. From that day, we all had to think on our feet, make quick decisions and work collectively. Lavanya took charge of figuring out the logistics and circulating information to the media through the WhatsApp group she had created. I volunteered to check on the logistics for the media, writing the press releases and transcribing Rahul Gandhi’s speeches. Neeraj, on the other hand, was commandeered to be one of the frontiers near the media truck. Over and above these tasks, we had to ensure seamless coordination between the AICC, the Pradesh Congress Committee and the